see him shouting from behind the window, that's when you knew there was real trouble and it was time to disappear over to the other side of the field. It meant Eric was on his way down.

When Eric was pleased with you, he made you feel great. If I heard him say: 'Great ball, David' once in the morning, that would set me up for the rest of the day. Likewise, if he criticized something, you thought a long time before doing it again. I remember one session when, every time I got the ball, I was trying to pick someone out with a sixty-yard pass. Even when I was young, I was able to see what was going on ahead of me and could strike the ball a very long way. That particular day, though, nothing was coming off and Eric wasn't impressed.

'David. What are you playing at? Hitting those flippin' Hollywood passes all day?'

Hollywood passes? I'd never heard that before. I knew exactly what he meant, though. And I thought twice before I hit the next one. Truth is, I still love playing those long balls; they're a part of my game. But, even now, whenever one doesn't make it, I imagine Eric, shaking his head and grumbling: 'flippin' Hollywood passes'.

It's not always been true with Alex Ferguson or other coaches I've worked with, but with Eric you always knew exactly where you stood. If he lost his temper with you, he made sure you understood why and, somehow, he had the knack of shaking you up without ever abusing you or putting you down. We always knew, however hairy it got, Eric only ever wanted what we wanted too: to get the best out of ourselves and to achieve everything we could as individuals and as a team. No wonder he commanded the respect of every single one of us young players. Some young players nowadays who sign for a large club suddenly think they've hit the big time. There was none of that with our generation. And if there had been, Eric would soon have sorted us out.

Everything at United was right: the facilities, the uniform, the training and the other players in our group. Who wouldn't want to have Eric Harrison as a youth team coach? I couldn't get enough of it all. While we were trainees, Gary and I would go back to the Cliff in the evenings twice a week, when Eric was working with the schoolboys on the big indoor ground, and join in the sessions just to get extra training under our belts. Phil Neville was in that age group—two years younger than me and Gary—and so was Dave Gardner. I don't know how you find your very best friends. Maybe they just find you.